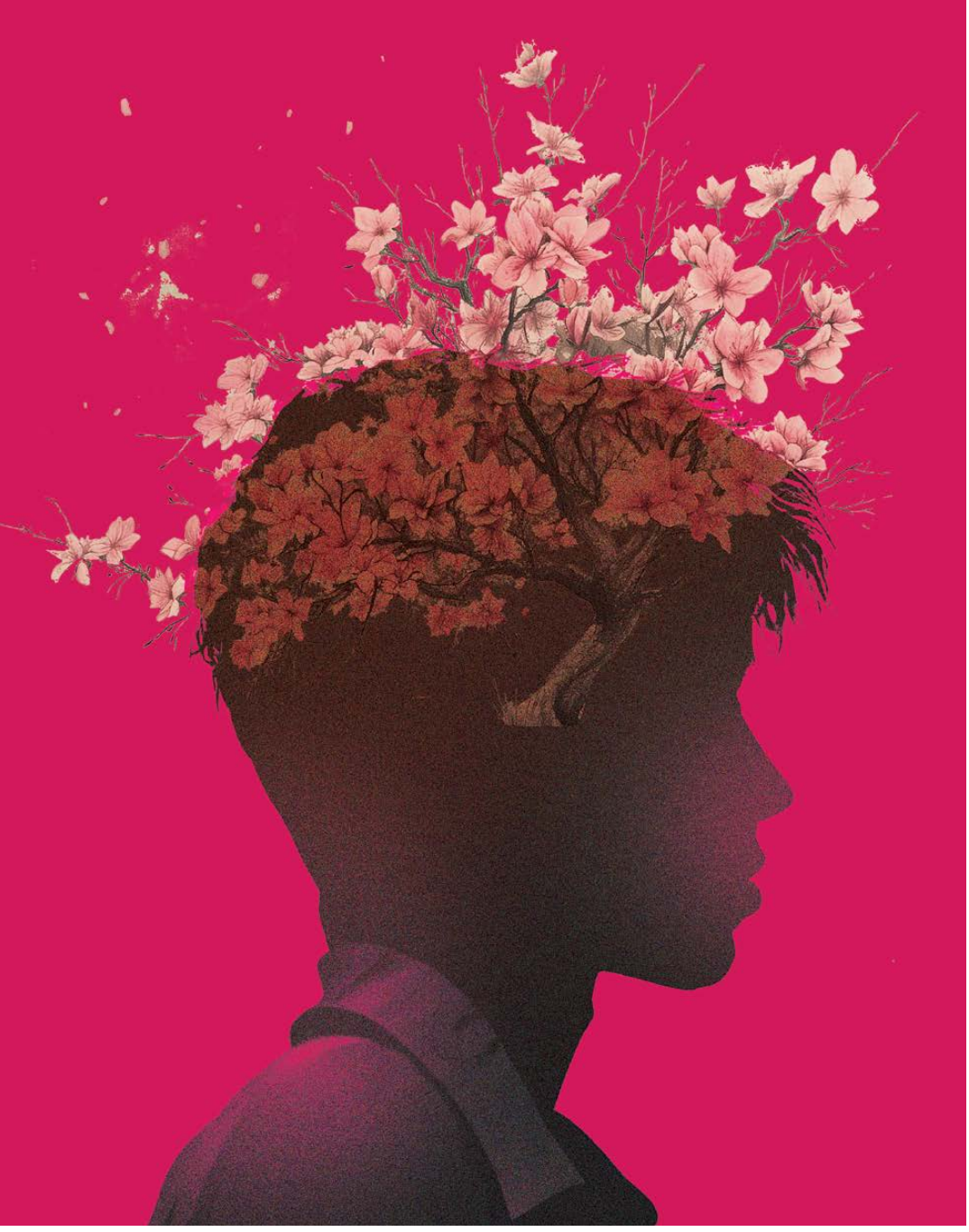


THE GIANT STEPS

- Young children will be exposed to a variety of activities, encouraged to explore the world around them
- In middle school, they would spend as much time outside class as in it, probe their immediate context, contribute to knowledge
- A student can take up basic courses in many subjects or go deeper and higher in a few
- After 16, students will be connected to a local establishment. They will have Anytime Testing Machines (ATMs) to test themselves in any subject of their choice

Choosing the path forward: As soon as the student is 16, she or he has to be connected to an enterprise and establishment nearby. For two years, young people participate for some hours a day in the world of work. Some employers actively seek apprentices. Some young people take initiative to find work that is of their interest. For others, it is still an uphill challenge. But it is now widely accepted that local economies must contribute to and gain from their young people's effort and learning.

Of course, they still are schools. But, these are not organised by grades; instead, they are set up as subject areas. A student can either take basic "courses" in many subjects or go deeper into a few. No longer do students have to wait for a whole year to move into a new class. No more are they tense about year-end examinations that will decide the course of their lives. Best of all, today any student can go to an 'ATM'—anytime testing machine—and test themselves in any subject at the level that they choose. Thanks to adaptive technologies, you can take tests as many times as you want and your best score will be recorded. Along with the testimonials from their work, their ATM test scores accumulate over time. Armed with these experiences from their high school years, young people can go forth into the world.

How far away are we from these schools of the future? The National Education Policy 2020 has outlined many of these transformative pathways. How quickly can we change our school systems and revise our family aspirations to support new and more meaningful ways for our children to learn for school, learn for life and learn for work? ■

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Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**